

for much of the year on meat. This reliance on hunting may have been inspired rituals that became the focus of cave art. By contrast, human figures in cave paintings are rare, and when they do occur are highly stylized or masked. Impressions of human hands and undecipherable signs do, however, appear on the walls of caves including Altamira in Spain, and Chauvet, Niaux, and Lascaux in France.

Magic and ceremony

Generations of archaeologists have argued over the meaning of Cro-Magnon cave art, which flourished until about 14,000 years ago. One theory is that the paintings were done by shamans (see box). In many hunter-gatherer societies, shamans were believed to act as intermediaries with



the spiritual world, using trances and hallucinogenic substances to pass into the realm of the supernatural. They were thought to communicate with ancestors, as well as retelling stories, and legends. They also passed ritual knowledge from one generation to the next. Late Ice Age shamans may have conducted ceremonies in caves, often painted with murals, where the acoustics lend themselves to chanting and singing, and in other less accessible caves far from daylight, where they may have felt closer to powers outside their immediate environment.

Surviving clues

In cultures that have survived up to more recent times we may find further clues to past beliefs. The American Indians and Australian Aboriginals live in worlds where the living and supernatural realms are treated as a continuation of one another. Both enjoyed elaborate ceremonial lives that included initiation ceremonies and seasonal rituals, as well as

commemorations of ancestral spirits. Hunter-gatherer societies that we know about today are almost universal in possessing complex beliefs and world views that are intimately connected to the natural world around them. Although we do not know that people in ancient cultures shared these rituals and beliefs, some of the artifacts and clues we have indicate this as a possibility.

Other forms of art provide further clues. The female figurines of hunter-gatherer societies (see p.30–31) may have been made as objects of worship, and related to a fertility cult. Carved antlers and bones similarly may have been connected with religious belief.

Grave goods

One of the earliest and most lavish burials found was in Sungir, Russia. The sheer richness and diversity of the artifacts accompanying the bodies

Aboriginal dreamtime

Australian Aboriginals enjoy a complex relationship with the supernatural realm that permeates their living world. Their art, such as this example from a cave wall, depicts mythic animals and humans and forms an important part of their spiritual beliefs—known as the Dreamtime.

shows that these people lived in a complex society with a strong hierarchical structure, and that they were concerned with what happened after death. One of the individuals, a girl of about eight years old, was found with the remains of over 5,000 ivory beads, which, it is estimated, each took over one hour to carve. The fact that such wealth accompanied the burials may indicate a religion in which these objects were needed to accompany the dead on a journey to another life. In other cultures food was left with the dead, suggesting a belief in an afterlife in which sustenance is required.

Some of the earliest buildings relating to religious belief may come from Çatalhöyük in Turkey from c. 7000 BCE, where murals are indications that the spaces were used for ritual purposes. However, until later periods when written records are preserved, our knowledge about belief and the afterlife can only be conjecture.

AFTER

Cultures throughout history have shared a belief in an afterlife and a higher power.

EGYPTIAN AFTERLIFE

The *Book of the Dead* is the common name for a collection of **funerary scripts** on papyrus, dating from c. 1600 BCE and thought to have been used by the ancient Egyptians as a set of **instructions for**

BOOK OF THE DEAD

the afterlife 68–69 >> The grave goods placed in the pyramids of the Pharaohs to help them in the afterlife are further indication of a strong belief in another life.

BELIEF IN ANOTHER LIFE

A belief in the afterlife or reincarnation is still a part of human thought and is key to many religions, including **Hinduism, Buddhism, and Christianity 144–47 >>**

CELTIC BELIEF

Deities connected with **death, fertility, and birth** are shown on the Gundestrup cauldron, dating from 2nd-century-BCE Denmark.



GUNDESTRUP CAULDRON

HOW WE KNOW

THE SHAMAN TRADITION

Shamans—doctors, priests, or medicine men—still exist in some cultures, including this tribe from the Sepik Region of Papua New Guinea (see right), where the shaman is believed to possess supernatural powers. By observing their practices and rituals, it is possible to draw some useful parallels with early societies.

Archaeologist David Lewis-Williams argues that much of the cave art of the San hunter-gatherers of southern Africa was painted by shamans in hallucinogenic trances. These types of drug- or trance-induced experiences are still seen today in a few societies.

